

The ECA Application Guide

How to get your foreign education assessed for Express Entry - which organization to use, what the report does for your file, and the mistakes that cost applicants months.

The 5-year rule

Your ECA must be **less than 5 years old** both when you complete your Express Entry profile and when you apply. IRCC's own wording: applying with an expired ECA means **your application will be refused**. If it will expire before you can apply, contact the issuing organization - some report types can be re-issued.

Who needs an ECA

- **Federal Skilled Worker applicants** with foreign education - mandatory. Without it you cannot meet the FSWP education requirement.
- **Anyone claiming CRS points for education completed outside Canada** - CEC and FSTP have no education requirement, but without an ECA your foreign credential earns zero education points.
- **Not needed** for education completed in Canada at a Canadian high school or post-secondary institution.

Step 1 - Choose your designated organization

Most applicants may use any one of the five designated organizations. Processing times and costs vary by organization - compare before you commit, because the report is tied to the organization that issued it.

Designated organization	Commonly known as
Comparative Education Service - University of Toronto School of Continuing Studies	CES
International Credential Assessment Service of Canada	ICAS
World Education Services	WES
International Qualifications Assessment Service (Alberta)	IQAS
International Credential Evaluation Service - British Columbia Institute of Technology	ICES

Ask for the report type for immigration purposes ("ECA for IRCC"). A standard academic evaluation from the same organization is not valid for Express Entry.

Regulated professions use their professional body instead

- **Architects (NOC 21200)** - Canadian Architectural Certification Board (CACB), designated 20 May 2024. An ECA issued for this occupation by another designated organization before 31 October 2024 is still accepted while it remains valid.
- **Doctors** - Medical Council of Canada, if your primary occupation is a physician NOC.
- **Pharmacists** - Pharmacy Examining Board of Canada, if you need a licence to practise. Pharmacists who do not need a licence for their intended work may use a designated organization instead.

Step 2 - Submit your documents

Once you choose the organization, they tell you exactly how to submit your documents - requirements differ by organization and by country of study. Most require transcripts sent directly from your institution, which is usually the

slowest step. Start the institution's transcript process the same week you open the ECA file.

Step 3 - Use the report correctly in your profile

	Enter the ECA report number and result exactly as issued - the assessed Canadian equivalency, not your original credential name.
	Assess your highest credential at minimum. If you hold two or more credentials, ask the organization to assess both - 'two or more credentials' is its own CRS education level and can be worth more than the higher credential alone.
	Check the expiry math against your realistic timeline in the pool - a report issued 4.5 years ago is a liability, not an asset.
	Keep the name on the report identical to your passport name; a mismatch triggers requests for explanation.

Sources

Every rule and figure in this document was verified against the following official pages on 19 July 2026:

- canada.ca/en/immigration-refugees-citizenship/services/immigrate-canada/express-entry/documents/education-assessment.html
- canada.ca/en/immigration-refugees-citizenship/services/immigrate-canada/express-entry/who-can-apply/federal-s-killed-workers.html

Important - please read

The information provided is for informational and guidance purposes only, based on publicly available Immigration, Refugees and Citizenship Canada (IRCC) regulations and policies. This does not constitute legal advice, and no solicitor-client or consultant-client relationship is created by accessing this content. Immigration regulations, program requirements, processing times, and CRS cutoff scores are subject to frequent change without notice. You are responsible for verifying all information with official IRCC sources (www.canada.ca/immigration) and confirming current eligibility requirements before taking any action.